

SPIRITUAL LAWS

Since there is no lecture in February, we issue instead excerpts of some basic spiritual and psychic laws, as they have been taught to us through this channel in the course of all these years.

The Law of Personal Responsibility

This is the main element of these teachings. It is the primary principle which guides the pathwork. At first glance, this is sometimes hard to accept. It seems so much easier to accept even defeat if only one can blame the circumstances or bad luck or other people's faults. Accepting the law of personal responsibility wipes out self-pity, resignation, passive endurance, smoldering resentments against the injustices of life, and the famous masochistic game of harping on "one's case against life."

Yet, this law which is apparently so hard is the most hopeful, encouraging, liberating, and strengthening truth of all truths. It enables the individual to resolve whatever problem he may have. It opens up life with all its rich possibilities. It forces him to see things in their true light, and uncomfortable as this may first seem, it leaves him in the end with a lot more self-respect, integrity, and hope than the helpless resignation to the circumstances life is supposed to bring about without one's doing. It makes defeat unnecessary because it also removes, among other things, the childish illusion of one's omnipotence, which is just as unrealistic as the illusion of being life's passive victim. To accept one's own limitations and the limitations of others increases the power to direct one's life meaningfully.

The law of personal responsibility is the guiding principle on the search for the root of one's obstructions. By contemplating one's life, especially the fulfillment and the lack of it, one can regard it as an instant blueprint that outlines the areas where there must exist an inner corresponding attitude responsible for either. This approach is diametrically opposed to the usual, but it is indeed a reliable and truthful one that must always lead to results, provided one goes deeply enough and is truly honest in this endeavor.

Whenever one arrives at a juncture on the path from which there seems no way out or where one cannot see how to change, how to resolve the entire problem, one can be quite sure that an important tool to unlock the door has not been found yet, no matter how profound previous insights and changes may have been. A total insight always shows the way out. Thus recognitions can be differentiated. Are they of the kind mentioned here? Or are they merely leading to them? The former always give a sense of joy, liberation, hope, strength, light. They infuse new energy into the entire system. The latter may have a temporary, debilitating effect on the personality. The former enable the person to recognize the most unflattering facts about the self without in the least

diminishing his sense of value, worth, and integrity -- quite on the contrary, they increase. The latter make the insight laden with guilt.

When one has experienced the difference of these two types of recognition, one can protect oneself from hopelessness or at least realize that the hopelessness is, in itself, a sign that the way out has not yet been found. It can then be an incentive rather than a weakening factor, to surge on with all one's vigor until the real way is open.

When an unfulfilled longing, a painful conflict of long standing is finally seen to be the result of an inner attitude with concomitant behavior patterns, one is no longer a helpless tool of fate. If such an attitude is completely seen, observed in action, and accepted for what it is, one may still be unwilling to give it up -- for whatever reasons and misconceptions -- but at least one sees a vitally important connection between one's inner life and the outer manifestations of it. It is then possible to embark on a special search for finding the reason why one so stubbornly holds onto a negativity, a destructive attitude.

Many of the following laws deal more specifically with this same basic principle.

The Seesaw Law or Law of Compensation

Wherever a "misconception" exists, a balance structure is disturbed and an opposite "misconception" must also exist. Each attitude has an opposite, which can either be a healthy complement or a distortion. Thus a distortion in one respect creates also a distortion in its opposite. When the pathwork has made the person conscious of only one side of the seesaw, it is impossible to resolve it, no matter how hard one tries.

Examples. 1. The person has a tendency to assume too much responsibility for others. He may come to understand clearly and with much detail that he is doing so, why, what the ramifications are, where it comes from, what other attitudes in him contribute to this, are affected by it, etc. Yet he finds himself unable to place other people's responsibilities at their doorsteps. He is either unable to recognize such a situation when it occurs (for this often applies to very subtle matters which are, however, no less important), or else he feels extremely uncomfortable and strongly compelled when he refrains from assuming this false responsibility. Such a forced act would be unnatural, not in tune with organic development. Thus the effects might be worse than giving in to the compulsion.

Real growth leads to effortless, natural, spontaneous change that comes so naturally that it may at first even go unnoticed. This ease will come once he sees the whole seesaw, namely in this case, the area where he does not want to assume self-responsibility and uses others as a substitute for his own conscience or authority. This may happen in a very different area and may manifest so subtly that it is almost imperceptible at first. It may be a purely emotional manifestation. For example, the individual may assume the burden of responsibility for others in a sense of feeling guilty in instances when his own reason tells him he need not feel guilty. At the same time, he may sell out his integrity for the sake of obtaining approval and affection from others. He thus makes them responsible for what he must first give to himself. Blaming life for one's unhappiness is another way of negating self-responsibility, as mentioned before. This always incurs an opposite,

compensatory attitude of accepting burdens not one's own. The interconnection between these two attitudes must be recognized in order to resolve it.

The healthy version of these opposites is a harmonious balance of proper self-responsibility and a freedom from assuming the burdens of others. (This has nothing to do with a free and loving act of wanting to help.)

2. The person who is too self-effacing and is unable to change this without going to an equally destructive opposite extreme (rebellious, hostile defiance) will find himself capable of changing effortlessly when he finds that, perhaps in a concealed way, he is too demanding. He may never openly express these silent demands; he may not even be clearly aware of them, not of his seething resentment when they are not being fulfilled. Healthy self-assertion that can be openly expressed and a flexible giving in constitute a balance. This is disturbed by an immature self-centeredness. It will be effortlessly achieved when this seesaw is deeply experienced.

3. Too much ego on the surface is often an indication of an inner weakness of ego. Conversely, a weak ego on the surface always means that under the surface the ego is too rigidly held onto.

4. (See lecture No. 169 -- The Masculine and Feminine Principles in the Creative Process)

The Lever Law

This is, at times, in a way related to the seesaw law. The difference is that the latter deals with opposite attitudes of one and the same basic principle or attitude. The lever law can bring a person to a certain point on his path where a particular distortion can only be relinquished when a completely different, apparently other principle or attitude is found and changed. This is then the "lever" he needs to open the locked gate.

Example. A person suffers from loneliness and lovelessness. It may have taken considerable effort to have uncovered these feelings which might have been denied and covered up by a mask of apparent certainty, contentment, sociability. Therefore such a revelation can easily appear as a major recognition, for it comes only after battling a great deal of resistance to finally shed the mask. It is nevertheless not the major recognition needed. Yet the seesaw law may not be applicable, for a willingness to love may exist -- at least to the extent that this is possible with the existing distortions which tie up vital energy. The "handlebar" may be found in a different department. A violation of integrity may exist, for example, in any number of ways which seem to have little to do with the problem of loneliness. But this violation of integrity gives the person a sense of not deserving happiness and love. The vague feeling of not being deserving that may surface at first when confronting the self deeply in this regard should not be glossed over lightly as irrational. One should search where and in what respect there may actually exist such a violation of integrity -- again, not necessarily in overt action, but in emotional attitudes, for instance in an expectation to get more than one is willing to give, etc. When this is fully recognized and when the person is able to give up the attitude that removes self-respect, a new sense of self, of deserving must ultimately also remove the lack of fulfillment.

Misconception; Conflict, Split; Vicious Circle

Every misconception creates duality, inner conflict, apparently insoluble problems, pain. It further creates a vicious circle. Every inner problem and conflict must reveal this sequence, and this sequence must be worked through and assimilated, both in intellectual understanding and in emotional experience, before the process can be reversed: truthful concept, unity, benign circle creating pleasure and happiness.

Example. A young man discovers insecurity about his masculinity, which he had not been aware of previously. It required considerable overcoming of resistance on his part to penetrate the mask of false security he had been assuming. He now finds that he had the common misconception that sex is dirty (not in his conscious mind at all). The thus resulting split was that either he gave in to his masculine sexuality and felt adequate as a man -- for which the price was guilt and a feeling of being sinful and unclean -- or he had to be clean and decent according to these unconscious standards, but then he had to forsake being a man. He constantly tried to compromise between these two undesirable alternatives. A tug of war was going on in him. He could not commit himself wholeheartedly to either being a man or to being a good, acceptable, decent human being. This unnecessary division resulted from a simple misconception lodged in the unconscious.

The misconception that sex is dirty led to the above-mentioned conflict. The conflict led to the vicious circle. The more he tries to be masculine with the guilty feelings of being wrong, the less love feelings can he have in his sexuality. Therefore the sexuality produced partially real guilt, as any loveless action must do, and partially false guilt for being "dirty." The cut-off sexuality becomes therefore more and more permeated with hostility, anger, and rage. When a personality is subtly infused with such emotions and cannot face them, all feelings are affected by them. The frustration that results from such conflicts, and their hopelessness, increase hostility, which compounds the justified guilt feelings. The loveless, hostile sex makes the taboo against it seem justified, and this is the worst of the problem because it makes the person go right around in circles. The more he is in this apparently insoluble conflict, the more he must hold back his natural, spontaneous feelings. The more he holds back, the less can he love. The less he loves, the less real masculinity he has, and consequently the less adequate and the more insecure and inferior he feels. This in turn must be hidden from the world and himself, which increases repression and pretenses. And on and on it goes.

False Guilt Produces Real Guilt and Vice Versa

The case history demonstrating the law of misconception, split, vicious circle is also a case in point of false and real guilt being interdependent. A childish misunderstanding often produces a false guilt. This must, in turn, produce attitudes and emotions, defenses and pretenses that lead to justified guilt because a spiritual law has been violated -- by these attitudes, emotions, defenses, and pretenses. Since misconception is unreality and since unreality cannot help but produce negative emotions such as anger, guilt, hate, hopelessness, distrust, it can easily be seen how it follows that false guilt produces real guilt. Moreover, misconception must lead to unfulfillment, therefore frustration and disappointment, which, in turn, produce resentments, bitterness, anger. Misconceptions, that is, illusion, are linked with unhappiness. They are further linked with helplessness and unhealthy passivity, which prevents the individual from doing what needs to be done in order to attain what he needs and wants. This passivity comes from the sense of futility that is inherent in all conflict arising out of misconception. The helplessness and the feeling of being

victimized by the meaninglessness that produces such situations are, in themselves, misconceptions. The false blame launched against the world makes the world responsible for the unhappy state.

Thus the real self sends the message into the consciousness, "You are wrong to be so resentful." The consciousness of the person is usually unable to interpret these messages correctly, but only senses vaguely that something is wrong about his self-pity, his accusations, his bitterness, his anger.

Whenever false guilt appears on the horizon in the course of self-confrontation, one must never let it go at that. Somewhere a real guilt is concealed behind it. It is as though the personality, unwilling to face up to the real guilt but pressed by his conscience, produces an unjustified guilt. This, too, may at first be hidden, but then when it is discovered, he can say to himself, "See, I have discovered it. I don't have to go on looking for what makes me feel really bad about myself. See how honest and conscientious I am that I feel so guilty even about unreal issues." When discovery does not lead to lasting relief, change, and greater inner and outer freedom, it can safely be assumed that some guilts have not been faced.

Childhood Trauma Not Directly Responsible for Neurosis

The childhood trauma only indirectly produces deprivation, unhappiness, unfulfillment, negativity, destructive feelings and patterns of behavior -- in short, neurosis. It is not, in itself, responsible for all that. The healthy soul experiences early unhappiness also with pain and anguish, but will throw off the effects without forming deep imprints imbued with negative patterns. These negative patterns are directly responsible for the unhappy experience in the present. And this is what must be clearly understood and worked through to overcome that which holds the person back from life. In the light of this truth, one's parents are not finally responsible for one's misconceptions. Resentment against them violates the law of self-responsibility. Similarly, one is not responsible for the neurotic patterns of one's child. Excessive guilt for this is based on a misconception. However, one is responsible for one's own distortions which might affect the child. Any example of one's own personal history, or those of others whose inner life one knows well, is a vivid example of this truth. This is why the dwelling on the childhood experience alone can only, at best, give a partial understanding; it cannot produce vital and significant change. The latter is possible only when the personality profoundly understands his destructive patterns and drastically changes them. This confirms, once again, the truth about personal responsibility.

Steppingstone or Stumbling Block

Personal freedom is, at one and the same time, relative, limited, and total. Since we must experience the product of our past attitudes and actions, we cannot help experiencing hardship and infringement when these attitudes and actions were based on illusion and were destructive. This binds us as long as we are oblivious of them. But we do possess the total freedom to choose our attitudes to the self-produced fate that comes as a result of the past. We can either dwell in self-pity, resentments, helplessness and thus increase weakness, paralysis, dependence, and destructiveness; or we can decide to want to make the best of this experience, learn the utmost from it, grow through it in awareness and self-perception. Through such an attitude, the apparent stumbling block assumes a new meaning whose effect on the personality can be vital, strengthening, and liberating. We then come to see that the stumbling block on our road was a direct result of our distortions. Thus we

eliminate for the future similar experiences -- perhaps worse -- because we made the result of the past a steppingstone.

Outer Situation Reveals Inner Reality

No matter what we believe we want in our conscious brain, our life situation reveals an unconscious, contradictory desire. Life cannot be cheated, and whether we like it or not, it produces exactly what the sum total of the conscious and unconscious personality produces. No matter how undesirable this result is, it nevertheless is an expression of what we childishly, blindly, or fearfully express into life. Not knowing this or not wanting to know this will produce bitterness and a sense of being unjustly victimized. Choosing this attitude can only increase blindness and makes us retain the destructive attitude that produced it in the first place. Or we can choose another attitude which is at first more difficult. This means, even though one does not see how the undesirable life situation is self-produced -- in fact this may even seem preposterous -- to nevertheless probe in this direction in a spirit of openness, humility, honesty, and with the wisdom that knows the human soul is complicated and many faceted. This latter course will bring amazing new vistas and new freedom.

It is therefore a tremendous short cut if the outer life situation is used as a gauge to determine what may be amiss inside the personality. If manifest unhappiness, problems, difficulties are used as an indicator to seek hidden fears, errors, and negative desires, it may even be discovered that there are fewer hidden negative attitudes than overt healthy attitudes. But by virtue of their being unconscious, they have a much greater power than the conscious, though perhaps stronger, positive attitudes.

It is therefore imperative to make the unconscious conscious. Vague emotional reactions, passing thoughts one usually does not pay attention to may reveal more about the unconscious state than seems possible at first. The conscious focusing of attention must be educated toward this direction. Then the contradictory wishes, the hidden fears, and negative desires will surface. When they are recognized, they can be reconciled with the conscious goals according to realistic values and aims.

Recreating Soul Substance from Negative to Positive Imprints

After one is thoroughly conscious of the misconceptions, after one actively experiences the negative emotions (it is not sufficient to know about them in theory, they must be fully accepted as a result of allowing the inner experience without being driven into acting the negativity out), the recreating can begin. The courage and honesty that was necessary in order to pass through this first state -- and which will have increased in strength as a result of the new self-acceptance -- must now be used for the purpose of instituting change.

The desire to change, the intention to change must be formulated in clear, concise thought-forms. The vision of how the healthy, productive personality functions, as opposed to the past destructive patterns, must be produced. Although the outer ego personality, with its will and intelligence, is required to initiate these steps, the very same ego must also recognize its limited power and require the universal self to guide, inspire, help at every step of the way. Thus the function of the conscious ego personality is a double one. (1) It must initiate, strengthen its own will, formulate thoughts, impress the distorted soul substance with the truth, with the picture of the

benign circles as compared with the vicious ones. (2) It must actively call upon the greater inner power and become more passive, receptive, and listening. It must step out of the way for a while so as to let the inner power reveal itself, which often happens when it is least expected, for a relaxed attitude is necessary. (Again, see lecture No. 169)

Groping for Balance Between Ego Functions and the Involuntary Manifestations of Universal Guidance and Help

It is not always easy to find the constantly fluctuating balance between inner action and the conscious ego mind. When to be active in thought formulation of new imprints and when to step aside and keep the self calm, open, receptive must be sensed. The feeling for this increases as one experiences the reality of the universal self more frequently. It is one of its remarkable attributes that the universal self can even be activated for the purpose of sensing more accurately how to perceive it, for more effective meditation, for proper inspiration and depth of feeling to meditate in a meaningful way. Each particular phase may require another kind of meditation, may necessitate different aspects of the universal power to activate. All this can come from within when it is asked for. The mind's limitations decrease as these limitations are recognized and the "vaster brain" in the solar plexus consulted. The ego must learn to alternate between being active and passive, initiating and receptive. Gradually a harmonious, self-regulating integration will occur.

You Must Lose What You Want To Gain

This statement was made by the Guide in one of the earliest lectures. It has the same meaning as Jesus' statement of the need to have the willingness to lose one's life in order to gain it eternally. Psychologically, it means that without the willingness to let go, there is such tension, such fear, that everything is taut inside and the good of life cannot come or be received. Only when one can lose without terror is winning possible. Conversely, he who is terrified of losing is never truly open to win. (In lecture No. 168, Two Basic Ways of Life -- Towards and Away from the Center, these principles are adequately explained.)

The Unitive Law

It is never true that one opposite is good and the other bad. Each can be either. In each, a healthy, productive alternative may exist, as well as an unhealthy and destructive one. To illustrate, the following examples will help.

One must be both active and passive in a harmonious interaction to live fruitfully. When one of these is assumed to be right and the other wrong, distortion and imbalance come about. One end of the spectrum of the active/passive principle will be exaggerated, and this inevitably also affects the other side.

Introspection can be productive and growth-bringing. Or it can be self-centered and separating. Its opposite, concern with others, can be an expression of genuine love and interest. Or it can be a means of evasion from the self. If introspection is healthy, automatically concern for others will exist in its healthy version. And conversely, if one of the two exists in the distorted way, its opposite must be distorted as well.

Self-assertion can be an expression of healthy autonomy, or it can be a manifestation of rebellion and reveal a spirit of hostile opposition. Just so, flexible adaptability can be the manifestation of a healthy psyche, or it can be submission and a disguise for masochistic self-denial. Again, if the former is healthy, the latter will be too, and vice versa. Yet, how often do people say, "It is right to be self-assertive," for example, when they merely cover up the unhealthy distortion of it. By the same token, how often does a person claim he is good natured and loving in his constant giving in, when he is merely afraid of asserting himself because he refuses to stand on his own two feet and wishes to cling to another person who must be "bought" by being submitted to. Such a person enslaves himself with the secret aim to thus finally enslave the other person.

Outgoingness, if genuine, is spontaneous and an expression of a warm, loving personality who wants to connect with others, who is capable of relating to others. Its negative, distorted version is pushiness, the manifestation of the inability to be by oneself. Conversely, being self-contained is the other side of the coin. In a healthy personality, it reveals the basic reliance on the person's own inner resources. This makes him capable to be by himself. In fact, he will need to spend time with himself. Only then is a genuine relating with and to others possible. In distortion, these two aspects become mutually exclusive alternatives where one is accepted as good and the other as bad, depending on the particular distortions and errors of the people involved. The unhealthy distortion of the self-sufficient person is the recluse who cannot cope with people and thus escapes into solitude. This may be rationalized by pretending it is the healthy version. Often in such cases, all outgoingness is accused of being shallow and lacking in inner depth, whether or not it is the healthy or the distorted version.

These and many, many other examples exist to illustrate the illusory concept of partnership, of judging one side or aspect of a wholeness as right and the other as wrong. If the distortion is very strong, it is relatively easy to recognize. But often it can be concealed by posing as the apparently healthy version. It is therefore noticeable that the deeper one is on this path, the less one is inclined to take one opposite and to put it up against the other. It is seen more and more that both form an integral whole. This demonstrates how duality must lead into the unitive principle in the course of this pathwork.

Many years ago in a private session, the following statement was made by the Guide, which can be helpful. If you do not want to be more than you are, you will never fear to be less than you are.

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